

Prices are dropping so rapidly, we're wondering when they'll begin giving out thumb drives for free with hard disks! Capacities have gone up to levels that make us double-check our decimal points: for example, in the RED ONE camcorder we touched upon in our November issue, the Flash memory is upgradeable to 128 GB!

For thumb drives, 256 MB, which was considered pretty OK in the beginning of the year is a sorry figure now, and any drive below a gig is most certainly small. Two GB is more like it now for any one of us.

The hard drive is inching ever so closer to death. We were happy with 40 GB disks just yesterday, it seems, and how much longer can it take for 40 GB of Flash to become *de rigueur*? And we'll be pretty happy with that much, until...

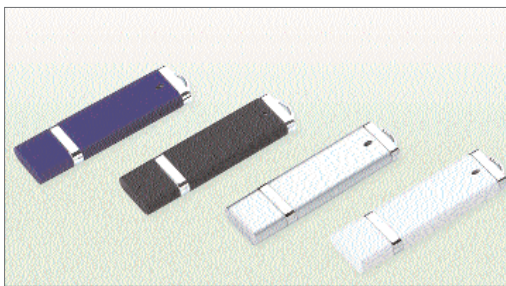
Until the hard drive catches up again. They're talking about HAMR (Heat-Assisted Magnetic Recording), for instance, which will boost capacities to a gazillion gigabytes or whatever it is we've come to expect.

CELL PHONES

2006 saw cameras on phones go way beyond the VGA and 1.0 MP mark, touching 3.2 MP. Naturally, we're talking affordable models, not those for the rich. March saw an interesting entrant, the Sharp 904SH. It did away with finger-printing, looking at your face via a second camera instead to decide it's you who's holding the phone.

Next step: video recording. Why not? The SE P990i and the Nokia N93, as examples of what 2006 has had to show off with, support video recording at 30 fps—and video calls over 3G networks. Don't ask us whether these phones have so-and-so feature... yes, they do. And are the cameras good? Yes, they are. Good enough for a band to have recorded an entire video on the N93. To view that video, head to <http://music.yahoo.com/ar-20234562-videos--Rob-Dickinson>.

Talking about 3G, the latest evolution of CDMA, called EVDO (Evolution Data Optimized) had come



Flash prices are dropping like heavy, over-ripe mangoes

out sometime in 2005, by network providers such as Sprint, but deployment was much more widespread by the early part of this year. EVDO was there for the asking in several areas such as North America, Australasia, and Japan, offering desktop-like broadband speeds on cell phones and laptops—typically in the range of 1 Mbps and lower; no need for Wi-Fi coverage. Since we don't get that much even on our broadband lines, and since there's no point you getting an EVDO-enabled phone, and since envy is one of the seven deadly sins, we won't go on about how cool EVDO is!

"Designed to be" an oxymoronic "indispensable luxury" as Nokia calls it, the 8800 is one of the latest in the not-so-new series of "lifestyle phones." The emphasis here is on design, the next frontier: the ad goes, "Created for your ultimate pleasure, its graceful looks and seamless functions will leave a lasting impression. Every aspect has been meticulously considered... from the laser-cut curves of its body... this phone is a masterpiece. Let the exquisitely composed ringing tones evoke your innermost emotions." What, a phone created to give us pleasure? That's a new one. The "ringing tones" should evoke our innermost emotions? That's even newer! And here we poor slobs are, with polyphonic ringtones that jar at worst and charm at best!

Along similar, narcissistic lines, the Motorola RAZR V3i Dolce & Gabbana is gold-plated. (For your pleasure, naturally.) You did expect some tie-ups somewhere with design houses of fancy-sounding names, didn't you? Well, we think "Dolce and Gabbana" is as fancy-sounding as it gets. Expect more of this neo-urban phenomenon in 2007!

And yes, the next "version" of Bluetooth—UWB (Ultra Wide Band) promises 40 Mbps to 1 Gbps transfers—and though people are asking if UWB will soon be coming to a cell phone near you, we wonder if we even need such speeds, but then again, someone will call us stupid in '07 or '08 for having said this.



"Cell phone" doesn't do the N93 justice

PORTABLE MEDIA PLAYERS

If 2005 was the year of the pods and their clones, 2006, too, was the year of the pods and their clones. Only, the pods had grown screens. No, actually, it wasn't a revolution or anything; they'd had screens before, but 2006 saw them become much more part of standard equipment.

You know you're in an age of something when more of that something doesn't strike wonderment: today, new, convergent gadgets

Power Ready Notebook Cases TC1900RBN

- Rollercase
- Ballistic Nylon
- Mobile Device Pockets



Travel Power Adapter TPA90DCI

With APC's Travel Power Adapter in your Power Ready Notebook Case, you can simultaneously charge a mobile phone, handheld PDA and laptop from a single airplane, car or mains power outlet.

Take Charge...with



For more information, call Toll Free Helpline No. 1800 4254 877/272 or Email: indiainfo@apcc.com Web chat: www.apc.com/in